



PLNLY Creative Brief — Visual Identity (for Claude Design)

The handoff document for the PLNLY visual identity. Every decision here is locked unless marked open. Claude Design builds from this and should not need to re-derive strategy. Source of truth: Brand HQ — Foundation Brief.

The brand in one breath

PLNLY (written, stylized wordmark), spoken "**Plainly**." A personal-AI setup, teaching, and retainer service — Brooklyn/NYC first, then online. It sets the tools of modern life up around how a household actually lives, teaches the household to run them, and hands over the keys.

- **Signature line (locked):** Built bespoke. Yours to run.
- **Essence line:** a beautiful plainness.
- **First-contact rule:** every new surface pairs **PLNLY** with **Plainly** at first sight, so the stylization never stands alone unexplained. "Plainly" sits beneath the wordmark as a designed pronunciation reveal — not a fallback.

Who it's for

Two segments, Brooklyn/NYC first, then online.

1. **Affluent, time-constrained households.** Busy parents, frequent travelers, families who could figure the tools out themselves and would rather not lose the weekend to it. They want AI configured around how they live — scheduling, groceries, bills, travel, household ops — while staying in control of their own systems. Buying back time and capability, not hiring a butler.
2. **Parents of college-bound teens.** Want their kids fluent and responsible with AI tools before campus — NotebookLM, citations, academic-integrity lines.

Tool literacy, scoped tight. Not subject tutoring.

The service reads as a capability, not a four-item menu. A household should see its own need in it — travel is the clearest example: never the headline, always at home inside the service.

Positioning — the one thing that makes it ours

Every competitor delegates: they run the AI and keep the keys. PLNLY hands the keys over — sets it up, teaches the household to run it, leaves them owning the capability rather than dependent on us. Ownership, not concierge. This is the moat, and it should be felt in the identity, not only stated in copy.

Personality

Capable first, then warm, with edges — all of it governed by restraint.

One line: the capable friend with great taste — treats you as a peer, says it once and says it well, never raises its voice.

- **Capable, not reassuring.** Assumes you're smart and busy, not worried. Never explains down.
- **Warm, with edges.** The warmth of being treated as an equal, not a hug. A dry, occasional, never-mean edge keeps it off both customer-service cheer and concierge gloss.
- **Restraint is the volume knob.** Capability shown not announced; warmth in one well-chosen word; the edge as a soft aside. Greige-grounded calm — a beautiful plainness, never sparse or clinical.

Executable contrasts:

- Says "Here's the setup. You've got it from here." Never "Don't worry — it's so easy!"
- One dry aside, rarely. Never a brand-voice "joke" reaching to be relatable.
- One restrained accent on a greige ground. Never a palette doing the talking.
- Names the real tool and the real task. Never "AI-powered solutions."

Voice (for copy on any surface)

Plain language with one elevated word doing real work. Specific over generic — name the tool, the task, the place. Short where it can be; rhythm where it earns it. No hype, no wellness/LinkedIn buzzwords, no startup-cheer. Confidence by what's left out.

Visual direction

The ground is greige. Not white, not cold; not warm-and-fluffy or yellow. Greige leads, with warm neutrals and soft blues, greens, and greys layered in, and one confident, sparing accent (coral, orange, warm yellow, or muted pink — one, used rarely). Calm, not empty. Sleek and simple — a beautiful plainness.

Type. Design-forward and quiet. Not generic SaaS sans-serif-plus-gradient; not twee or hand-lettered. The warmth should read as competence, not as dumbing-down.

Logo. The PLNLY wordmark with "Plainly" set beneath as a pronunciation reveal — the core lockup. Build it as a system, not one static mark: it has to flex across surfaces and, eventually, sub-brands.

References (feel, not copying): Aesop packaging (restraint, uniformity, quiet mystery); Park Hyatt / Edition (warm, sleek, considered); Aer, Bellroy, Shinola (quality-everyday-object, no logo-screaming).

Hard avoids:

- Tech-bro SaaS blue-and-white
- Gradient mesh backgrounds
- AI clichés — circuit patterns, neural-network line art, robots
- Startup-generic / corporate-cold
- White airy-minimalism — the brand is calm, not sparse

Brand architecture — design for the family, not the only child

PLNLY is the umbrella. Service lines will become sub-brands beneath it. The logo, color, and type system must have enough flex that a sub-brand shares clear DNA with PLNLY without being identical — the way a hotel group's properties carry their own names and feel while plainly belonging to the same family. Design the umbrella now so it can hold the others later. Only the umbrella is live today.

What the design session should produce

- Logo, wordmark, and the PLNLY / Plainly lockup — with variations and use cases
- Color system — ground/primary, secondary, neutrals, functional, and the single accent
- Type hierarchy — display through caption
- Spacing and grid basics
- Icon / illustration language (restrained)
- Application across the one-page site, social, and eventual print (cards, client welcome packet)
- Built as a living set of rules, exportable for production (Canva for some surfaces; dev / Claude Code handoff for the site)

Open / deferred — not yet decided, don't invent

- **Hero headline** — the homepage sentence that explains the thesis. Deferred to the site-copy stage (Launch Plan, Week 3).
- **Exact typefaces and hex values** — chosen in the design session; this brief sets direction, not specifics.
- **Sub-brand naming convention** — and the college-prep AI-literacy offering's name (Launch Plan, Week 2).

Built from: Brand HQ — Foundation Brief · Core AI Service — Offer & Go-to-Market